move out, I was proceeding on leave and the two of us travelled together to Jammu where I gave him a sort of farewell dinner at Asia Hotel, then the best hotel in Jammu. Over dinner, I jokingly told him that, if he came back alive, I'd treat him to dinner again. During his deployment at Siachen, Narendra's post was hit by an avalanche and he was trapped in the snow in a small air pocket till he was rescued after about four hours. He told me later that all through those timeless minutes, he kept going over my offer and hung on, saying again and again to himself, '*Sir se dinner lena hai*' (I have to have dinner with Sir). When I recounted this tale to my mother, she had tears in her eyes and she wrote a short story based on this account, which was published in a leading Marathi magazine, the payment for which she asked me to hand over to Narendra.

Binaguri

The command of the Battalion had passed on to Col Ashok Kapur, the first officer to be commissioned in Lucky Seven who also went on to command the same Battalion. This was the time when the command of Battalions had been upgraded from Lt Col to Col. Col Kapur's wife, Farida, was the daughter of Mr Dotiwala, who had been on the faculty of the NDA, teaching us international relations and area studies, and had even taught me. In fact, Col Kapur had met her when he had been posted to the NDA as an instructor. Because of this Pune connect, as also that we had the same taste in books and music, we always shared a special rapport. Soon after taking over the Battalion, he appointed me as the Adjutant when the post fell vacant when the incumbent officer, Maj BK Sharma, proceeded on another posting. It was under Col Kapur that we went to Binaguri, West Bengal.

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